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**Uzbekistan's first
unicorn, Uzun, leaps to a
\$1.5B valuation**



At a time when the world feels increasingly divided between East and West, Uzbekistan has emerged as a rare middle ground, as the Central Asian nation's homegrown unicorn, [Uzum](#), has raised \$65.5 million in a new funding round co-led by China's Tencent and the New York- and London-based VR Capital, with participation from U.S.-based FinSight Ventures.

The all-equity round brings the Tashkent-headquartered startup's post-money valuation to approximately \$1.5 billion — a nearly 30% jump from the \$1.1 billion valuation it announced when it [first hit unicorn status](#) in March last year.

IMAGE CREDITS: UZUM

Founded in 2022, Uzum started its journey in Uzbekistan with an e-commerce marketplace called Uzum Market, and shortly after its success, the startup added fintech with a debit card and later expanded into its express food delivery service, Uzum Tezkor.

Uzum currently boasts over 17 million monthly active users — nearly half of Uzbekistan's adult population, or about two-thirds of all smartphone users in the country — and 16,000 merchants. In the first half of 2025 alone, the startup recorded \$250 million in gross merchandise value (GMV), up nearly 1.5x year-over-year.

Its digital banking arm, Uzum Bank, launched a co-branded Visa debit card with pre-approved credit

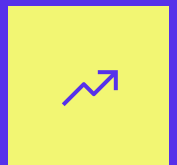
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limits in August last year. That product has already issued 2 million cards and is on track to surpass 5 million by year-end. Meanwhile, Uzum's unsecured lending business hit \$200 million in financed volume in Q1, growing 3.4x from the same period last year. The startup also [posted](#) \$150 million in net income in 2024 — a 50% year-over-year jump.

With a portfolio spanning e-commerce, fintech, and digital banking, how has a startup just over three years old managed to scale this quickly — and draw the attention of global investors like Tencent?

Uzum founder and CEO Djasur Djumaev attributes the success to a combination of deep local knowledge and disciplined execution. He believes that understanding the country's culture, consumer behavior, and business environment — and pairing that with the technical and operational expertise that global companies have developed — has been critical to building a business that can scale quickly and sustainably.

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The startup built its digital and physical infrastructure from scratch to kick off its business in Uzbekistan. This includes setting a logistics capacity that has grown to 112,000 square meters, with a storage capacity of 1.1 million square feet, allowing it to process more than 200,000 orders per day.

The startup has also set up more than 1,500 pickup points across 450 cities, towns, settlements, and villages in the country to enable next-day deliveries. These pickup points also allow the issuance and distribution of Uzum Bank cards.

“Betting on local expertise and infrastructure in frontier markets gives you an advantage to then perform and scale your business very fast,” Djumaev told TechCrunch in an exclusive interview.



UZUM'S PICKUP POINT.

IMAGE CREDITS:UZUM

Initially, Uzum operated on a fulfilled-by-operator model to enable e-commerce deliveries. It has since expanded to include fulfillment-by-seller and delivery-by-seller options, with a goal of routing 20% to 30% of deliveries through these new models. These new delivery models will also help

Uzum expand its stock-keeping units, which are currently over 1.5 million available for its next-day delivery service, up from over 600,000 SKUs at the time of its last funding announcement in March 2024.

When asked what brought Tencent onto its cap table this time, Uzum's chief strategy and business development officer, Nikolay Seleznev, told TechCrunch the startup's strong growth metrics convinced the Chinese investor to come on board after several quarters of ongoing discussions.

Uzum plans to grow its fintech business by introducing a deposit product in September and a long-term (more than 12 months in maturity) credit facility for its B2C customers. The startup also plans to expand its merchant base and help its existing and new merchants with its QR code payment processing system, expand its Visa debit card program, and build new products to support small and medium enterprises in the country.

Similarly, the startup plans to introduce new products adding value-added services to its e-commerce business, including those helping to generate advertisement revenues. It is also working toward scaling its financial infrastructure further with AI increasingly embedded across credit scoring, fraud protection, and personalized user experiences.

Furthermore, Uzum plans to open up its e-commerce marketplace for international merchants, beginning with those in China and Turkey in September.

"We are expecting 10 to 15% of cross-border activity coming from these countries," Seleznev said.

The startup has over 12,000 people in its workforce, including blue-collar workers at its pickup points,

as well as tech, engineering, and product teams across all its business verticals.

Similar to other businesses of its sort, which are profitable and have multiple avenues to generate continuous income over time, Uzum has plans to become public in the medium term. But before that, it aims to raise a Series B round of \$250–\$300 million in the first half of 2026.

That said, the startup has so far raised \$137 million in equity, including the latest round.

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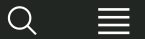
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A private equity bet in Latin America proves the strength of fintech investments there

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The deal, which values Prisma at \$1.42 billion, is yet another sign of Latin America's growing prominence for global investment and the central role that fintech plays in the development of an innovation economy in the region.

Prisma Medios de Pago is the leading payments company in Argentina, and one of the largest in Latin America, with a full suite of services including point-of-sale hardware rental, e-commerce gateways, transaction processing, payments processing and electronic bill pay.

Its newest business line, TodoPago, offers peer-to-peer payments, mobile wallets, point of sale

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offerings, QR code payments and e-commerce payments to merchants.

Across Latin America, fintech startups have hit billion-dollar valuations and raised hundreds of millions as investors vie for a piece of the region's growing e-commerce and financial services markets.

Brazil's StoneCo Ltd., a provider of payment technology and services, is worth more than \$6 billion after its October 2019 initial public offering. It's a decline from the \$9 billion pop the company had back when it debuted on the Nasdaq, but still represents a healthy valuation for the Latin American technology company.

Waiting in the wings are companies like Brazil's NuBank, [which reached a \\$4 billion valuation](#) last year on the strength of a significant investment from the Chinese technology giant, Tencent.

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Nubank is now worth \$4 billion after Tencent's \$180 million investment



Nubank, the Brazilian financial services company, has raised \$180 million from the Chinese internet giant, Tencent. Tencent has long been interested in financial services startups, and with its \$90 million direct investment and another \$90

million investment in the secondary market, the company now has access to what is arguably the largest digital banking

At the time, company co-founders Cristina Junqueira and David Velez said the opportunity for financial services startups to achieve significant scale was far higher in emerging markets like Brazil than in developed markets, because the barriers to banking are so much higher.

Financial services, Velez said, has been controlled by massive oligopolies that have erected unfair obstacles to wealth creation for the masses. Nubank and other companies like it are working to change that.

An article [from Fintech Futures](#) last year outlined just how large the opportunity was for Latin America. In 2018, roughly half the population of Latin America was unbanked. In Brazil, about 40 percent of the country have no access to traditional banking services and its small businesses face a credit gap of \$237 billion, according to a McKinsey study cited by Fintech Futures.

Investment in fintech has soared alongside the opportunity. Two years ago, fintech investment on the continent nearly hit \$600 million, and public offerings like Stone and PagSeguro point to public market appetite for the sector.

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Meet Uzbekistan's first
unicorn: e-commerce
startup Uzum

Uzum, an e-commerce startup offering online shopping, fintech and food deliveries to millions of customers in Uzbekistan, has raised \$14 million in funding, becoming the country's first unicorn with a valuation of \$1.6 billion.

Uzbekistan is fertile ground for startups, given the fact that people aged below 30 constitute about 60% of its population of over 35 million. The country also enjoys a near 100% literacy rate (according to its government), more than 76% internet penetration, and over 75% smartphone penetration rate. In 2020, the Central Asian nation had nearly 1,200 startups, 85% of which were at the seed stage. Fintech startups dominated the market with a 30% share, followed by e-commerce startups at 27%, according to estimates (PDF) by the Asian Development Bank.

However, the country seems to have a shocking lack of e-commerce services, which may be among the reasons why the sector accounted for only 2.2% of Uzbekistan's total retail market as of December 2022, per a report (PDF) by KPMG. According to Uzum's co-founder and CEO, Djasur Djumaev, Uzbeks used to primarily shop online through social media apps such as Instagram, TikTok and Telegram. Customers connected with sellers in groups on social platforms, who had limited stock-keeping units (SKUs) and no logistics to speak of.

"It was a surprise for us to see that the penetration of smartphones was high and telecom infrastructure was in place, but there was no e-

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commerce, no proper fintech,” Djumaev told TechCrunch.

Djumaev clearly saw the potential for a company to do in Uzbekistan what Amazon has done in a lot of other countries: offer a cohesive marketplace that promises end-to-end logistics and delivery. Uzum started by setting up its logistics, a fleet, and established pickup points to offer next-day deliveries. The marketplace was launched in October 2022, and today, it has more than 8 million monthly active users and over 9,000 merchants selling 600,000+ SKUs. In contrast, the biggest street bazaar in the country has about 70,000 SKUs on any given day, according to Nikolay Seleznev, chief strategy and business development officer at Uzum. In its first full year of operations, the startup recorded gross merchandise value (GMV) of \$150 million and expects run-rate GMV to reach at least \$300 million this year.

Shortly after its success with the marketplace, Uzum forayed into fintech with a buy now, pay later (BNPL) product. About 45% to 50% of its e-commerce transactions are done via the BNPL solution, Djumaev said. Uzum has also entered the food delivery business and set up a digital bank to bolster its growth.

“Because we attract customers on e-commerce, we retain them on high-transaction businesses like daily banking, which is 100% digital. We monetize them on our lending or credit products, which are 100% Sharia-compliant, which is also very appealing to at least 85% of the population in Uzbekistan,” Seleznev told TechCrunch.



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The Series A round, comprising \$52 million in equity and the remaining \$62 million in debt, was led by FinSight Ventures and saw participation from Xanara Investment Management and Uzum's senior management. Uzum has diluted less than 5% to investors participating in the Series A round, which is the startup's first external funding. The startup also plans to raise about \$200 million in a Series B round this year from investors in the Middle East, U.K. and the U.S.

Uzum plans to use two-thirds of the fresh funding for its fintech business and one-third for the e-commerce arm. There are plans to launch new products for unsecured lending to individuals as well as small- and medium-sized enterprises and invest in its own IT and logistics infrastructure.

"We want to expand the products, enhance the infrastructure of our e-commerce, and fund our fintech," Djumaev said.

Seleznev said the startup intends to expand its GMV by 150% to 200%, grow its credit portfolio at least two times, and increase the total payment volume circulated through its ecosystem.

By the end of this year, Uzum plans to combine all its businesses into two super apps: one for its consumer-focused offerings and another for its business-focused products. It also aims to launch the country’s “largest” logistics complex for e-commerce in June, planned to span 112,000 square meters initially, and expanded to over 500,000 square meters in the next few years.

Djumaev said a few companies globally operate similarly to Uzum and named Latin America’s Nubank and Kazakhstan’s Kaspi.kz. However, he doesn’t see any competition in Uzbekistan, as Uzum has the advantage of enjoying different margins across products and can make higher margins by combining its e-commerce and fintech services.

“We witnessed the success of Kaspi.kz in creating a super app in neighboring Kazakhstan, and we are confident that Uzum, which has the necessary talent, resources and products, will repeat this success to become a national tech leader in Uzbekistan,” said Alexey Garyunov, managing partner of FinSight Ventures, in a prepared statement.

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